

"Good culture and structure **lead to winning matches,**" says head coach Sjoerd Marijne. "There's no other way"

roped in Taeke Taekema to guide the drag flickers, besides another camp with David Williamson to work with the goalkeepers. The next few months is when the preparation takes centrestage.



The team visited Australia in the last week of May to play four matches (which ended in a draw) as part of their preparation for the upcoming Nations Cup being held in Auckland (June 15-21). Then, there is the World Cup in August, followed by the Asian Games in September-October. Marijne, for one, is unperturbed. "We are focused, but it's important to enjoy the journey together, so there's always time for a good laugh. But you need to switch between the two really fast because I can be quite demanding," he says. For Marijne, it's all part of the recipe to have his outfit in cracking shape. ■

—Shail Desai

SPORTS ▼

BACK IN THE RING

Her Asian Boxing Championships gold has only raised Preeti Sai Pawar's ambitions in the run-up to the Commonwealth and Asian Games

The mood was tentative when Preeti Sai Pawar stepped into the arena at the Asian Championships in Ulaanbaatar, Mongolia, in April. The doubts were soon past her. The bantamweight boxer scored unanimous decisions in all her bouts, and bagged gold. "It's been three years since I won the Asian Games bronze and much has changed since, both technically and physically," says Pawar.

Modest, yet confident, it has taken patient rebuilding for the 22-year-old to emerge among the best again. For five months after the 2024 Paris Olympics, Pawar was away from the ring, recovering from Hepatitis A. When she resumed training towards the end of December, she struggled and considered giving it all up. "I remember the first track session where I was a minute and a half slower than usual. And ring workouts where I would be exhausted after a couple of sets where I usually did 5-6 repetitions. When you don't finish training sessions, it really takes a toll," she recalls.

Through most of last year, the team at Inspire Institute of Sport put her through the paces and monitored the progress. Away from the ring, Pawar indulged in art to take her mind off the travails of training. At her first competition in April 2025, Pawar felt like her body was getting back on track. She returned to the national camp in July and at the end of the year, picked up gold at the World Cup in New Delhi.

After rejoining the national camp, she's looking to continue building towards the Commonwealth and Asian Games. "The focus is on getting technically stronger and being able to adapt to situations that arise during a bout. I've recovered mentally and physically, ready to continue putting in the work," she says. ■

—Shail Desai

KNOCKOUT PUNCH After months away from the ring due to Hepatitis A, Preeti considered giving it all up due to strain

